Silent Nights of Firefly Light

By Eric Benson

Darren, 15, is verbal and enthusiastic. He is intellectually challenged and lost his hearing at age 13. He carries a stuffed animal (Snoopy)

DARREN: **(Pgs 3-8)** *(singing)* "Have yourself a merry little Christmas, let your heart be light, from now on our troubles will be out of sight ... "

Oh. I'm sorry about my voice, sometimes, my family says I get a little carried away when I sing. I think maybe it's because I don't wanna forget the . . . tunes of my favorite songs. Sometimes I think every time I sing one it's a little worse. I don't know how much time I have, so I think I'll introduce myself now. Okay? Okay. I'm Darren Alexander Dennon. Yes, my initials spell dad. I like . . . potato salad, playing frisbee and the color orange. My mom says that when I was really little, I would come out of my bedroom in the morning wearing orange from head to toe. I guess she'd make me change most days because she said I looked like a caution sign or something. What do moms know? I don't like artichokes (because they're hard to say and eat), alligators and my kindergarten teacher. Oh. This is Snoopy. He likes strawberry cupcakes. I love Christmas and . . . my sister, Holly. I hate . . . myself.

INTRODUCTION

Darren Alexander Dennon, a 15-year-old is obsessed with Christmas and singing and his little sister Holly. He is the best big brother in the whole world even though he knows Holly was born because his parents wanted a smarter child who wasn't deaf. So, Holly became the family's Christmas miracle. She brought so much joy. Until . . . a tragic accident forces Darren to learn what it means to lose what you love most.

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DARREN: I haven't always been like this. My ears have gotten a lot worse, which makes a lot of stuff really, really hard. Mom and Dad took me out of school after fourth grade because my teachers thought I was "too difficult." I think maybe they just got tired of having to make sure I wasn't crying because all the other kids were mean to me. But

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Mom says it was for the best and now a lady who smells like Windex comes and reads to me and stuff on Tuesdays and Thursdays. I didn't mind so much, because it meant I got to spend more time with Holly. She's almost six.

When mom and dad told me they were going to have a baby, I was really mad. Snoopy remembers -- They wanted another kid who was smart and could hear. One they could talk to everybody at work or the grocery store about. But, as mom's stomach got bigger and bigger, and people started to put Christmas trees up in their living rooms, I got excited to meet my little sister. Holly was born at 1:25 in the morning on Christmas. I waited in the waiting room with Grandma and sang *(singing)* "Grandma got run over by a reindeer, coming home from our house Christmas eve . . . " Until she told me to be quiet because the family across from us was staring. I thought it was funny.

Holly was the tiniest person I've ever seen, and I know I sound like a total cheese ball with extra cheese, but my entire heart moved up to my throat and made hot sticky tears run down my face the first time mom let me hold her. She was so light, like a tree ornament or maybe even a snowflake. I sang to her whenever she cried. *(singing)* "Deck the halls with boughs of Holly, fa la la la, la la la la, tis the season to be jolly la la ... " What, Snoopy? No, I won't forget, just calm down. I'm trying to tell this, okay?

Holly's first word was "Dar Dar." Dad likes to tell people it was Da Da and blames me confusing it on "my condition," but I saw her mouth move . . . Dar Dar. When she turned two, I put her in the biggest box I could find and put her under the Christmas tree with a gigantic red bow. I made sure Snoopy sat in the box with her, so she wouldn't get lonely. I thought it was going to be the funniest, best Christmas ever, but Mom and Dad didn't. Sometimes, I think they wish I disappeared when Holly was born and I maybe I should've. That's how great she is. It's kind of like all the stuff I'm . . . rnissing, Holly has. She's the brains and ears for both of us. I think I lost all of my "comprehensive hearing" when Holly was four. It was about three weeks after the fourth of July and I was sitting outside with Holly counting the fireflies on our porch. It

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wasn't sudden . . . I just kinda realized I'd stopped hearing the crickets chirping, and that Holly wasn't singing that song, have you heard it? *(singing)* "Jeremiah was a bullfrog da na nuh . . . " but when I looked at her, her mouth was still moving, so I told her I couldn't hear her. I guess she started singing really, really loudly, her eyes so so wide, with her little hands fluttering around like the fireflies. Mom and dad came outside, probably to tell us to quiet down, but when they saw Holly's face, and me holding my hands to my head, to see if the big quiet was living in my brain, right? They started mouthing angry, scared words at me, which made Holly start crying, and the worst thing about that was that I couldn't hear. . . anything. Just. White. Firefly. Light.

A week before Holly's birthday last year we were shopping with mom at the market for groceries and wrapping paper, when I noticed that Holly's big blue eyes were staring at someone. Not in the nice staring way. I turned around from pushing the cart and saw some kids from school. I guess they were making fun of me, because one was walking funny with one hand cupped to his ear and the other hand hitting his chest. Like this. *(demonstrates)* I just put my head down. I didn't want to cry and have mom get upset at me, but Holly marched up to them like nothing I've ever seen and started moving her mouth really fast. The next thing I knew, mom was walking us out of the store and shaking her hand at Holly who was smiling the biggest smile I'd ever seen. She held my hand in the car all the way home.

I wanted to make Holly the best present this year. Usually, I give her two separate things. One birthday. One Christmas. But this year, my plans were so great that I knew that just one would be okay. The only thing was that I needed to make sure my parents would leave the house for just a couple hours. It took six days to convince them it would be okay. They could see some movie and pretend they liked each other and I would make sure Holly ate dinner and took a bath, and then they'd come home. No sweat, right?

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The big night arrived and I had bought the blank cassette tape. Dug the dusty old tape recorder out of the basement. Sound proofed my room the best I could with my old comforter duct taped to the windows. I made Holly Spaghetti O's for dinner, well, she mostly made them and I sort of . . . watched her, we ate together and had some milk and went upstairs to start her bath. Extra Mr. Bubbles, not too hot water. I was good at this big brother thing, right? I made sure she was okay, and said I was going into my room to do something. She wrote "Ok, poop face" in the steamed up mirror.

So, I went to my room. My big surprise was to sing every single one of Holly's favorite Christmas songs and record them. They probably sounded pretty crappy because of. . . me. But I knew she would love them. I'm a good big brother. So, Jingle Bells, Rocking Around the Christmas Tree, Here Comes Santa Claus, even Do You Hear What I Hear? When I looked at the clock it was 8:45 and I had started singing at seven. I thought, Holly must be a big prune by now, the water must be freezing. So, I walked down the hallway to the bathroom doorway. But, something wasn't right.

Holly was. Holly was. She was . . . Why does she look like that? Her face was under the water and she was not moving. And the water in the bathtub was not the color it was supposed to be. It was red. It was all red. Holly had slipped and hit her little head in the bathtub. I may be slow and deaf and stupid but this was definitely not how little sisters who hold your hand and write poop face in steamed up mirrors, and make everything okay in this very, very crappy world are supposed to look when you leave them, like a good big brother, like the best big brother in the entire world to take a bubble bath.

And I did hear something then, for the first time in two years. My heart. I heard it beating in my throat. Pounding. I dialed mom's number and started screaming and screaming as loud as I could. I didn't know what else to do. Today was Holly's birthday. Merry Christmas. I am the worst big brother in the entire world. I can't change how stupid I am. And I know that.

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I tried to go into Holly's room yesterday, because I just needed to be around her stuff you know? But mom or dad . . . or maybe grandma put a lock on the door. I don't really know why they did that. I tried to give my mom a hug today, just to remind her that I am here, but she just looked at me, her eyes watery and strange, like there wasn't anything behind them and walked away.

(singing) Silent night, holy night, all is calm, all is bright, round yon virgin, mother and child, holy infant so tender and mild, sleep in heavenly peace . . . "

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
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